EXECUTIVE BRIEFING · OPERATOR LAYER

MODULE 4 INSIDER PLAYBOOK — THE 21-DAY CAMPAIGN: The Add-Cycle Clock & Chart Mechanics

Frequency Dominion · Confidential Operating System

Executive briefing. The execution layer under the lessons. Read after 4.1–4.4.

THE ADD-CYCLE CLOCK (SCHEDULE YOUR CAMPAIGN INSIDE RADIO'S RHYTHM)

Radio acts on cycles, not on your energy. Align the 21 days to the industry calendar:

Day	Industry reality	Your move
Mon	Rotation boards refresh; add decisions from Friday reads	Load + verify (no sends)
Tue	New-music Tuesday: most commercial add dates	Wave 1 — first half of the list
Wed–Thu	College MDs process; specialty hosts plan weekends	Wave 2; touch-2 value to wave 1
Fri	Week's rotation locks; specialty show prep	Log; no cold pitches after 11am
Sat–Sun	Specialty shows air; hosts are reachable and excited	Host DMs, thank-yous, value drops
Next Mon	Fresh rotation board	Touch-3 grace closes land on a fresh week

The insider rule: the campaign is a weekly machine, not a 21-day sprint. Each week of the campaign rides one rotation cycle. If you fire wave 1 on a Thursday and wave 2 on a Friday afternoon, you've just burned two weeks of cycles in one send — which is why the Load → Tue/Thu → next-Monday rhythm is the actual operating system.

THE IMPACT-DATE MOVE (HOW LABELS TIME A CAMPAIGN)

Labels don't tell a station "this is out." They tell the station **"this is the impact date — play it the week of [date]."** That frames the add as a scheduled event, not a favor:

> "Official impact: [date]. Rotation-ready. We're servicing [NUMBER] markets that week."

Your version: give your campaign an internal impact date. Announce it in the pitch — "servicing [city] stations the week of [date]" — and time wave 1 exactly 1–2 weeks before the impact so the add lands on the week. PDs are calendar animals; a date converts "maybe" into "when?"

THE COLLEGE CHART EXPRESS (SERVICE → ADDS → CHART → SECOND WAVE)

This is the mechanic the whole campaign optimizes for:

1. **Service** (wk 1): 10 college slots + 4 specialty — the Tier-1 allocation.
2. **Adds** (wk 2): rotation boards pick up; you track adds daily in T4.4.
3. **Chart** (wk 3): college stations report to NACC/RMR. Chart position is evidence.
4. **Second wave** (wk 4): the chart listing becomes the proof line for every commercial and mid-metro pitch: “charting at [NUMBER] college stations, NACC top [NUMBER].”

Run this loop and you’re doing what labels pay $2,000+ per record for — with 20 stations and 21 days. The first add’s real job is to start the chart. The chart’s real job is to make the next 20 stations easy.

THE ROTATION-UPGRADE STRATEGY (THE KILLER FOLLOW-UP)

Most artists treat a light-rotation add as the end. Operators treat it as the **start of the upgrade campaign**:

- **Week after the add:** thank-you + listener-feedback receipts (streams, tickets, requests).
- **Two weeks after:** second receipt — usually market-specific (“your metro streams +30%”).
- **Three weeks after:** the upgrade ask: “Is there a path for [SONG] to move into medium? We can support with [asset].”

The upgrade ask is the single most winnable ask in the industry — it’s a category change, not a new favor — and it’s the one almost no independent ever makes.

THE SPIN-TRACKING DISCIPLINE (WHAT LABELS CHASE)

Spins are the industry’s raw score. Track weekly per station: `adds`, `spins`, `rotation category`, `chart position`. The total spin count is your **momentum number** — the number that appears on the second-wave pitch, the sync package, the sponsor deck, and the booking email. Without weekly spin tracking, you’re running a campaign without a scoreboard. With it, you’re running a business.

THE 3-TOUCH ESCALATION PSYCHOLOGY (THE INSIDER VERSION)

- **Touch 1:** the ask lands. Silence = the PD is not deciding yet (busy, not hostile).
- **Touch 2 (value):** the receipt or asset gives them a new reason. This is where the “busy but interested” cohort converts.
- **Touch 3 (grace):** the close. Politeness + an open door. This is where the “I need a deadline” cohort converts — and where the “no” cohort converts into a relationship instead of a burn.

The system’s secret: all three touches are about the next campaign too. Touch 3’s grace close is what makes touch 1 of your next release warmer than touch 3 of this one.

THE ONE SECRET MOST ARTISTS NEVER LEARN

Adds happen in waves, not trickles. If you see 2–3 adds land in one morning, the rest of the week’s board is likely moving too — that’s the rotation cycle turning. Watch the wave: when it turns, escalate the second-wave pitch to every station that hasn’t added yet, with the fresh proof. Timing the second wave off the first wave’s momentum is the difference between 5 adds and 11.

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